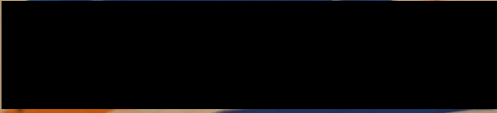
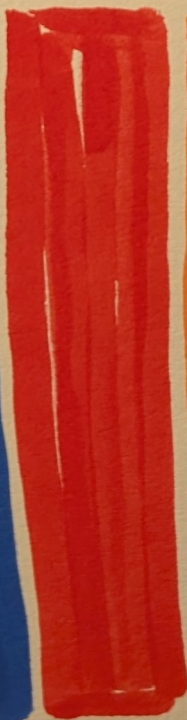


Short

Stories



In [REDACTED]'s debut collection of short stories, they explore perceptual distortion, the role of symbolism in cognition, dread of passing time and the role of memory in experience.

Critical responses to [REDACTED]'s work:

"[...]stands out for its intense internal focus and emotional honesty. The narrator's voice feels controlled, reflective, and self-aware in a way that captures the complexity of guilt, avoidance, and emotional detachment. Lines that explore the tension between "loving tenderness" and not loving the person are particularly compelling. You're doing impressive work with interiority, allowing the reader to sit inside a difficult, uncomfortable emotional space." -- [REDACTED]
[REDACTED]

"Cool concept." -- [REDACTED]

"Without knowing much of the main character, you get this sense of dread that they carry around whenever they think, as there is little to no optimism throughout any of their monologues." -- [REDACTED]

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Along the Tigris-Euphrates

I wanted to explore an aspect of cognition that is often seen in psychotic states or mystical experiences where fantasy, or the experience of the transcendent, become identical with reality. I attempt to do this through the use of ancient Mesopotamian myth, which functioned as a symbol system that structured perception. In early cosmological thinking, gods were present in everyday events and described feelings or ideas, and carried a function we use abstract categories for in the present day. Multiple gods could be present at once and were often fused with each other. For example, when ancient Sumerians had an experience of awe that they associated with the experience of looking up at a limitless sky, they called that the presence of Anu.

Along the Tigris-Euphrates

Squat and trapezoidal, the building's architecture appeared, to him, to resemble a ziggurat. Here, the silt accumulates in layers, becoming heaven and earth. Here they come together, where he lives, writing his research on Assyriology, steady.

Inside. Phone rings: it's Will's mother. Will, she says. Have you gotten out lately, I think it would be good for you to get out. Can you help me. I have an errand, she says. This intrusion is unwelcome, makes him uneasy. Already, attention scattered, not looking good for him. He says, knowing his mother's predilection to, in an uncanny way, suspect when he's on the verge of it, and make the call, that he's quite busy. But, she protests. I can't get out in this weather, I'm not young like I used to be so I really can't do it myself. Besides, she says, you shouldn't be inside so much, I'm worried about you. Sighs. Ok, what is the errand? Can you pick up some milk from the store, it is so cold outside, bring it over please? He agrees, unfortunately, knowing what's next.

So he descends the steps. Outside it's a mess, eroding winter in its fullest expression. Every icy breeze an assault, especially the slow ones, the slow, deep, rage-inducing wearing-downs, chipping at his resolve. The recognition is immediate, he remembers yesterday and the day before, anticipating struggle and quickening its coming. The recognition makes itself actual. Molasses-like trudging to the bus, like a dream walking struggling through the water, tiny impingements by atoms, he pictures, tiny

tiny sharp cold, dry atoms. The terrible, barbed particles tear away smally at his senses, an affront to morale. Going to get milk, trained myself for this, he braces for thousands of small impacts just skating beneath the surface of acknowledgement, barely seen, fast-moving, sensations intended to undermine. Unfocused, he goes on, what else, anyways.

Cars swiftly passing straight through, and you can't see one at a time, you can't fix it in place, hold it, examine it. Together a raging torrent, blaring loud, wheels spinning: ever-closing approximations to something past already, trying to hold or put together the pieces, dissolute and the dissolution extended, scattered around and torn to shreds. Enlil asserts his terrifying might, Will's eyes wide, barren of Anu's ordering temperance. The river floods, the Elamites assault consciousness and coherence, everything in ruins and wondering why, despairing, and how much longer. Roaring bubbling forth through the intersection, hard to make sense of it all.

Lucky: it comes together. The regular traffic patterns, the stabilizing effect of stoplights and crosswalks. The cars, yet no less terrifying in their power, impress him with a kind of awe when the perception coheres, chaos permeated with structure, inseparable organization from its material. A feeling as if pondering the immensity of the sky, destructive, incomprehensible mass set to order. He thinks of his work, already homesick.

As one might predict, the bus arrives, rudely. He clambers on, taking a seat in the back by a window. It's moderately crowded

onboard and he watches the people today. Busy with their phones, scrolling, texting, crushing the barley with the pestle. The phone scroll has a kind of rhythm. Routine, repetitive and familiar, controlled and controlling. He looks over out the window, taking in the passing scene, white falling in zigzags. It's easy to feel the soft, slow falling. This, too, feels even, ordered. The length to the store is one continuous attempt to apprehend the view, outside the window and the people, too, what would give that feeling of realizing it. He strains for the thought that elevates the scene to comprehension and totality, wanting to see, again. It's a waiting game. You do some thinking, let it go, relax, then wait for the unconscious to come back with something. Sometimes he feels like the soil is too full of salt, barren; reworking the soil again and again offers diminishing returns. He's not convinced of his mastery of crop rotation.

Frustrated, arriving at the store and anger rising. It's busy, crammed, lights blaring, offensive in the utmost; long long lines trailing from the register. He starts walking towards the rear of the store. Five steps in, a person is blocking the aisle have to go around, weaving in and out bubbling, frothing and overflowing, he maneuvers deftly, swiftly, through the crowd. His phone rings and it's his mother. Will, she says, did you make it to the store. Half there half not, and tells his mother that he is near done. Good, she says. The call concludes but its impression lingers. The impression pressed itself on the situation. He is living attendant to anticipation of the next moment and every

experienced felt second is stretching towards the end, the only thing he can see is the whole thing, the whole thing so far in the distance making each second a strain, an exertion, the pressure of the moment oriented towards the end and passing imperceptibly slowly. Let's get this over with. He speaks the word to himself. The phone call is over but he feels the lingering effects ever-present, it's impressed itself on the present. All of this circling while he walks to the back. Many more people to dodge, dodge that thought, stop. He tells himself to stop. As he quickly tries to purchase and exit.

At the back of the store someone's in front of the milk freezer. He eyes them. Waits. He wants to cast his giant net, to shoot the arrow straight into the heart of Tiamat, to separate the heavens and the earth establish his temple, the final victory, the leaving, walking out, his mind is drawing images of walking out the front door and then backwards, fantasizing about the register, all while he waits behind this woman at the milk freezer as she takes her time, time that seems to stretch out and drag to eternity, in pain. Eventually and finally, she closes the door and walks away.

Got the milk victorious and relieved. The winding ascent the return victorious. He can set the world in order victorious. Momentous momentarily until the next victorious. Heaven and earth separate, Marduk's everlasting temple erected. Yet, even now, he still knows that the river is capricious, inscrutable.

Chinese Ghost Cities

In this story, I explore unusual perceptual states. I wanted to track the emergence of delusional ideation and provide an experiential account of perceptual distortion and hallucination. These experiences are often treated as merely pathological and incomprehensible on a human or subjective level. I find that a reductive approach to explanation based in biological psychiatry is incomplete, though useful. I believe that delusional narration emerges to explain phenomena that can be understood on a subjective, humanistic and existential level.

Chinese Ghost Cities

David was sitting on the cold unclean floor smoking pot. No idea what time it is, heavy curtains protecting him from the consideration of when he slept last and how long for. All the days are together, one unbroken stretch of time free from the rising and setting of the sun, an eternity, or a timeless present.

He thought about Carl, the bastard, the way he'd come in friendly and once he's left you notice things in your house gone. Or always asking for a loan. Something part of you ripped out, a hole in the home. Ava was like this too even though she wouldn't rob you. She'd cajole and convince, flatter and then you'd find out what she's said when you were gone. What she'd done with the love extended. Ava and Carl, really, the same person. A flash of an image, bringing the faces to memory. He pulls up his phone and scrolls through his photos, comparing their faces. Look at how similar they look. Pulls up messages and scrolls. He decides they sound the same. But he'd seen them in the same room together, so how does that work? More a puzzle than a contradiction requiring rejection of his theory, he'd seized on this idea and extrapolates. He wonders if there aren't more than 1000 real people in the world. The thought of this unpopulated world makes him feel simultaneous awe and deep aloneness, but it's beautiful. Laying down, he remembers the radio playing.

Feeling hollow and full of the radio emissions it's the only thing inside of him. Becoming the music it orders his perception, the rhythm is thought and feeling according to it, all sensation.

Sad song so he is this particular sorrow as it is drawn from beat to beat, identity expressed experienced as the shifting of melody. The song carries him along in the unpopulated world, he sees quickly succeeding images of empty cities, expansive plains, vast dry deserts sparsely inhabited fused to his idea, looking around the room where he's alone affirming the reality of his aloneness, affirming the story the music tells, that there are less than 1000 people. He's seen the stories of unpopulated Chinese ghost cities on Twitter, built to attract without a preexisting population and decides this too must be the truth of the greater world but they're only telling us so much.

A knock on the door and it's Ava when he goes to check. Alarmed and cautious, revealing nothing of his earlier realizations because something is holding him back, he can't quite say what, but he knows he's not supposed to share things like this. A violation of a felt, intuited rule. He lets her in. She's wearing a bright red sweatshirt, commanded total attention so fully he felt and became red. The woven texture wobbles in place, visceral. She's rendered in high fidelity, her sleek black hair just as consuming and fused with the assaulting red fused with the eyes and fused with feeling, possessed of an aura seizing his focus totally. Feeling in the eyes, a situation that he would be at pains to describe if asked, and something necessarily private about it. When she turns around to descend the stairs the bright and ominous red-black sleek-soft and assaultive and, too, portending something very secret, a promise of revelation that is

deep in extension and total blackness. The shining gleam of the dim light in the staircase red-black every microscopic fiber and hair-strand stands out individual. Timid light with bold darkness giving spirit and feeling to the light. He follows her feels like he's descending a tunnel into the pits of the earth. The light-dark hits him with blaring intensity through shared illumination and consuming shadow. Feels like he could watch forever.

Inside, Ava takes a seat on the couch. She's waving and the red-black texture taking on kaleidoscopic tones now, defined at the level of the fabric of the shirt, appears she's approaching while never getting closer. Quiet and shifts her head the straight arrow gaze piercing David deep inside and he can feel. David, captive to, wants to find the truth of it. Thinks he can keep looking forever as it keeps showing its endless self deeper and more revealing. She asks for a hit softly and breaking the gaze and David dutifully obliges. Breathing in deep and on exhale, cascading smoke swirling like tidepools in the ocean. Who knows how deep the water is but his gaze is firmly fixed on the ceiling and entering inside of it also again felt inside. Ava asks, are you alright, you seem like you're thinking about something. Yeah I'm fine, he says he knows he's lying distantly, captivated by the senses. Ava is shifting, her form is unclear and it contains so much now, shadows don't definitively determine but instead infinitely suggest change the depth of a trench, if you tried to pin it down to something concrete you'd come up with nothing but a swallowing vacuum.

Remembering Carl, and suddenly overtaken by an intimation that Ava is a devil-figure. The qualities of the perception become defining, mental, but on the cusp of physical realization. The time Ava asked for a hundred dollars and then he'd heard what she'd said about him not a week later, Ava and Carl laughing together, Carl coming over and fifty dollars gone missing. Ava now looking thin, shadowy ghostlike, stretching to the ceiling disappearing into ether. Unable to decide where she stops and ends the sense again shows David Carl and Ava who cannot tell you what they are. Nearly seeing, the sense on the fringe of perception, Ava stands, outline simmering and unclear can not tell the thin fringe from the stuff it bounds. Where does she start and end, yet this in front of his face, confounding by being more real than anything prior. Appearing as one thing and another but being something else, the shifting lack of definiteness the truth of the world, uncertain, unable to comprehend and ultimately it's a whole lot of nothing. She smokes and dissolves but he's resolving her into successions of comprehensions, the red-black and the devilishness of Carl and the dim shadow-light at once but, apprehension shifting to apprehension, a story telling itself, but still constant, through successions, unreality suggesting reality inseparably in turn all at once. Maybe there are fewer than 1000 people, maybe just one, or two.

A couple hours in near silence, David consumed privately, Ava decides to leave. Again alone but knows that with Ava he was still alone. Wonders about the truth of his body, hollow, nothing, in

extension with Ava. The music is gone and the wind blows through him empty as he is. He feels his nonexistence deep inside, dead if he was ever alive, inhabiting wandering the uninhabited world. He sees what he knows.

Sixteen Years

This is a story about dread and time, repetition, and the persistence of human connection. It is told in the setting of a prison, where the narrator is facing sixteen years and his friend John is doing life without parole. The narrator comes to understand that his actions did not have the finality he sought and that he must keep living. This fact is repeatedly faced through his interactions with John.

Sixteen Years

The day I shot Steve was the day I handed my life over. I was sure I was done and the shot was merely an admission and a reconciliation to the truth of that situation. But Steve didn't die so I didn't get life. I bear the reconciliation to that fact, that I will see the outside again and, even now, am living.

Wednesdays I cook with the other inmates on the tier. We all put in some commissary and come up with something we can share. When I first arrived the creativity impressed me. Life goes on here. Something stirred, the first I'd felt in a long time. One early Wednesday stands out in particular. John is doing life, but his family has stood by him all the same.

"Ruth's graduating high school next month. She's going to send the pictures," John says.

"You should be proud," Martin offers.

"I am, wish I could be there more than anything."

I'd only been here for a few weeks at this point, and John and the other guys were just starting to open up around me. John's reserved delivery was something I felt and noticed and filed away.

John's bed is decorated with letters and drawings from his children, nieces, nephews. At night he sits and writes long letters to his wife and kids. During the day he works laundry with me. We get paid, though the amount is meagre. We pass the time, sometimes in relative silence, sometimes with idle chatter about his family, the news, inmate drama. In this I started to feel the texture of the place, bleak and lonely as I'd ever been. But I

felt something else, too, the small, pitiable warmth that gave the coldness its sting.

On Fridays we have group therapy for our tier. The new guys are always cautious, standoffish. A lot of them just show up for the time reduction or because they've been mandated to attend by the courts. The guys who are in here with serious time, who have been coming for a while, use it as a refuge. We usually go over a CBT worksheet that's on rotation; I've done some of them too many times to count, now. One Friday John showed up in a real bad way. We started out going over the sheet but he couldn't focus. Back on the tier I asked him what was up.

"I'm missing my kids' lives. Ruth is graduating high school and I won't be there. I miss my wife. That part never gets easier."

I didn't really know what to say so I just listened. He didn't say anything else really. After a while I went back to my bunk. I saw him looking at photos and letters like he always does.

I laid in my bunk that night staring at the ceiling. I had sixteen years left and then what. I wake up tomorrow and then what. John will never see his family on the outside but he will see the light of day tomorrow. Ruth still loves him and his wife picks up every time. They send him commissary money. He goes to work, to group therapy. Even John looks to his future.

I pulled out the book I've been reading from beneath the mattress and try to anchor my attention on the page with little success. The memory of my sentencing churns in my mind. I play the

images back. The look on Steve's mother's face. The calm of my public defender and the judge enacting the procedure. I feel the same simultaneous dullness and anxiety, spaced out as I was, every bit as resigned as the day I pulled the trigger. I jump ahead, sixteen years ahead, this stretch of time contiguous with the present moment, the anticipatory dread of this moment stretching itself out to cover an amount of time that is hard to even grasp. Functionally, it is an eternity. I roll over and bury my face in the mattress and pull the blanket over my head.

The next morning I rouse from the same troubled sleep as the last day, and the day before, and... half-present, I make myself a cup of instant coffee. The first thought to visit is, again, the sentencing. It's a memory I can't resolve, lurking, waiting to command my attention when I'm unguarded. I carry it to my job that day. A quiet day for John, too. He's got his own festering sores to pick at. That day, out on the yard, I walk in circles. The laps give me something to attach my mind to. The image of the judge's demeanor coming back over and over has somewhere to land here. The motion feels true to me and it's here that I feel most at ease. Sometimes I hang back and watch the other inmates shoot hoops, lift weights. This is where they seem most alive, too. I remember one summer looking up at the sun beating down, hot on the asphalt, bringing shadows to life under the trees. I thought of the time on the yard the day before, identical to this one.

That night, John approached my bunk. I think his thoughts were getting to him.

"I got a letter from Ruth. She's thinking of studying psychology when she goes to college next year."

"Psychology?"

"She says she's interested in the way people's minds work. She's always been good with people. She said she wants to do something in law enforcement, like being a parole officer or something. "

"That's interesting."

John looks at the TV for a moment, then back to the letter he was holding in his hand.

"I'm thinking of trying to get into that welding program or trying to get my GED. Gotta do something with all this time here."

I nod.

I remember the next night too. The usual procession of local news and then a block of *Family Feud* reruns. Steve's mother's face had left me, the loop finally exhausted itself. A fleeting moment of peace. I laid in my bunk and flipped through a magazine I had read too many times. Boredom drove me to it as a matter of habit but the repetition was draining and irritating; I came to expect some relief through association, but the habit had worn itself out, run its course. I got up and took a shower. After that I had some ramen and resigned my attention to Steve Harvey. This had some effect.

I looked over at John's bunk and I saw him filling out a request form for information on programs. My attention shifts to the top of his bunk. I think of Ruth sending him letters about her

graduation. I think about his wife who calls him on the phone every night. Sixteen years is a long time. A lot can happen to a person in sixteen years. The spell broke, even if only for a moment.

Cat Got Out

Concretely, this is a story about a man whose cat escaped. On another level, it is about anxiety and anxious thinking. I wrote this more quickly than any other story in this portfolio, which helped me capture the moment-to-moment subjective experience of anxiety; moving quickly allowed me to capture the associative nature of this kind of thought.

Cat Got Out

My cat got out, fuck. I couldn't find him in the house and I searched the place up and down. All his spots: on the bed, in his favorite living room chair, under the couch, in the bathroom. Not just once, but twice. Fuck. He must have snuck out when I was bringing in the groceries. I shouldn't have been so absent-minded, so careless. I'm always on guard. How did this slip my notice? Maybe being "constantly on guard" actually means that I'm paying real close attention to my thoughts, my anxieties, my worries, not paying attention to the world around me. I was always in trouble in class for daydreaming, that's right. My math teacher yelling at me in high school for not paying attention. How could I let myself think I was attentive? No, I need to find the cat, that's right. Get it together.

I walk outside and frantically scan the bushes. I'm not looking close enough. Look again. I get on the ground and scan real close, no dice. I look around the back of the house. Behind the trash cans. He's not there. I'm already sad and I haven't given it my all. I give up too quickly. I'm always predicting the worst, getting sad before it's even warranted. I need to try harder. This is why my life is like this. God I'm such a fuckup. I see the neighbor mowing his lawn. While looking down both ways across the street, hoping to see my beloved-- and not get plowed down by a moving vehicle-- I cross. I approach the neighbor, nervous about how I must appear, after all, I never talk to the guy. I don't want to startle him. Unconsciously I feel like some

kind of freak, the way I always feel when I try to talk to someone, you'd think with familiarity the feeling would wear off but it never does, even with people I know. How well do I really know them though, I'm a recluse, I don't feel close with anyone I talk to. Anyways, I walk up to the neighbor to tell him the score.

"Hey, have you seen a medium-sized brown tabby around? I think my cat got out," I say.

"Oh no," he says. "I haven't seen the guy but I'll keep an eye out."

"Thanks," I say, relieved to be able to scurry off, which I do, immediately.

I go back to my yard and do another round of looking. Nothing comes up. I feel pathetic and helpless. I head around the back alley now, looking through the trash. Involuntarily I imagine someone watching me digging through the garbage and I recoil. I start coming up with explanations that sound plausible but aren't true in case someone shows up because I think the real reason might sound ridiculous and false, even if it's true. Oh, I think I might have thrown away my credit card. But then I wonder if they'd think it's not really my card and I'm lying to cover up the fact that I'm trying to commit fraud against a stranger. Anyone who sees me would recognize me, right? That I live here, that this is my own trash, but I'm not assured of this, I don't know my neighbors. I come outside to smoke all the time. I assume my neighbors are thinking badly of me now. He doesn't ever talk to

anyone, weird guy, and the smoking's disgusting. Right, I remember the cat.

I decide to walk down the block a bit. There's a huge raccoon on the sidewalk. I stand, frozen, he does the same, I hope my cat didn't get into a fight with an animal, that raccoon looks like it could do some damage. I move forward and the raccoon runs. I'm nearly to the park a block away from my house now when I encounter another one of the neighbors.

"Hello, I live down the street and I think my cat got out. Have you seen a brown tabby cat anywhere today?"

The neighbor flashes a look of recognition.

"I think I did, about ten minutes ago. He went down that way," he said, pointing to the park. Shit.

"Thank you," I say, before rushing in the direction of the park.

When I arrive at the park there are a couple families there. I tell them what happened and ask if they've seen my cat. Yes, they had seen him there. I start looking around and, the kids, having heard the situation go to assist me.

I go out to the walking trail behind the playground. After a few minutes of careful looking, alarm goes off, I saw him. He looks scared and I'm fully alert, trying to think of the best way to get him to come over to me. I get on my knees and start calling him over but he doesn't budge. I move a bit closer and he takes off, fuck. I follow him down the trail and manage to corner him near the middle. I get ahold of him and he calms down. I'm not

calm, but at least he is, which is something. The kids start laughing at the cat and I feel sheepish, embarrassed. They come over to greet him and I endure. I start walking home with my friend held close to my chest. At least he's happy.

The Plumber

This story is a fictionalized account of my own recent need for a plumber. Told over the course of a few hours, it explores various themes, including memory, violence, time and dread. Recently, I have been reading the Iliad, and have been interested in how nature symbolism, used to describe war, naturalizes it and portrays the human struggle as one based in combat and conflict.

The Plumber

There's a piece of laminated paper floating slowly on the surface, one of the only things resisting the consuming black water. I opened the basement door to this nightmare last night. Thick dark water halfway to the stairs. When I saw it I let out an agonized groan and turned around, bent back, dramatically as I did, in horror.

I made my way up the stairs to get my phone to start looking up numbers. I remembered my friend Dan telling me about lawsuits raised against Roto Rooter and these other big companies, how they scam you like mechanics do, so I wasn't sure who to call. Scrolling through my phone, I barely register numbers listed on Google, overwhelmed by the list of drain services I can't really distinguish from one another. I think about calling some of them, but feel paralyzed. I try and think of some questions to ask to filter them, but I don't know anything about plumbing and can't come up with anything. Any of these guys could pull one over on me. Thoughts scattered to the wind like frothing water molecules hitting stone at the end of a stream, I sat leaving the work to the unconscious, willing an idea to come while trusting nothing. Eventually, I decided to call Dan, who after his usual joking around recommended a local outfit that he thought was trustworthy.

I put the call into the drain service. After the call, I sank back into myself. Now I was consumed with dread over the cost, which I wasn't sure of. Drowning in anxious speculation, I attempted to brace myself for the worst. I'm not sure this is the

best strategy. Assuming the worst as fact is just as irrational as unreflective optimism or uncaring. Increasingly I feel there are two ways of apprehending the future. One way is a kind of expectant dread, which is really a collapse of temporality into an eternal, hellish moment, one without real access to past or to the future. The overwhelm of the immediate feeling is inescapable, closing off both the past and the future. Hell is here, now, and now is all there is. The other is a true connection with the past and an openness to the future in the present, one of possibility, where I really know the good. Life is choosing between one or the other. It takes an effort to remember. This memory is what gives life to the present.

I was sitting there, dreaming again, thinking these thoughts I've had too many times. Stale, stagnant, circling. The plumber is going to be here in a couple of hours. Like I'd never had these realizations, I'm back to worrying about the fee; insight doesn't translate to the elimination of a problem. I know very well what I'm doing. Changing, that's something else.

I got up to make a pot of coffee. I had a few hours to kill. I turned on the TV and put on some courtroom footage on YouTube. The courtroom environment was solemn, grave. This guy murdered someone. There's only one sentence for that kind of crime, but I waited in anticipation for the verdict all the same. The proceeding was tense and formal. There was a victim impact statement, which was arresting; the primary victim left behind a wife and two kids. It was the wife who made the statement today.

She cried while recounting her best memories with her husband and listed his virtues. The birthdays and Christmases that would never come again, his love for his family, how much he was valued at work, how much everyone cared for him. Victim impact statements in these sorts of situations have a kind of uniformity to them, but the emotion rendered is always very real and often heartwrenching. In their sameness is universal experience and pain. Maybe in these common forms, we should see distilled human experience in its pure expression. I imagined the husband playing with his children, his children crying when mom says he's not coming home today. I thought of my deceased mother and the last time I saw her, in the hospital, receiving her last rites. The tremendous sorrow that snuck in for months, a year after as I the grief consumed me. The picnics in the backyard by the stream, the way I'd watch the creek flow on never stopping. As a very young kid I'd make a game of trying to empty the whole thing bucket by bucket and it never exhausted itself. I wondered where all the water came from and how there could be so much of it.

Of course, the defendant was looking at life without parole. When the sentence was passed, I focused on the look on his face: tunnel vision. He's walking into hell himself, staring down the prolonged death of the rest of his days with clarity few achieve. It's easy to tell yourself you have all the time in the world, to distract yourself from what's waiting at the end, to forget time. I think the happiness we do achieve comes from forgetting time. Sometimes you can't forget time and there's a danger in being

unable to forget it, too. For me it's easy to live in the dread, this laser focus on bare time passing that will rob you of life. I watched a few more of these videos until the plumber arrived.

The cat was terrified of the plumber. The sound of the saw raged from the basement, like a river crashing on rocks, using erosion to make its path; the way to a habitable home resting on top of centuries of blood and conquest, coalesced in this one terrifying instrument. The strength of this man, reclaiming territory like we've done for centuries, in the constant back and forth between death and life. The basement floods; Rome exhausts itself through expansion; Napoleon gathers Europe under his empire; I call someone who can wield a saw. In fifty years, I will be dead, and someone else will occupy my home.